

Westhampton, MA Finance Committee Meeting Minutes
Westhampton Town Hall
April 22, 2026

Meeting called to order at 7:02pm

In attendance: Stephen Holt, Maureen Dempsey, Tad Weiss, Scott Stanton (taking notes), Jen Milikowsky, Jeremy Durrin, Jon Albitz

Also in attendance, Susan Bronstein, Scott Johndrow, Meaghan Schwelm, Julia Lennen, Doug Finn

Motion to approve minutes from 4/15/26 as amended by Durrin, seconded by Albitz.

VOTE TO APPROVE: 7-0-0

Discussion of the best method for going through this budget. Decided to go through line by line and hold numbers for discussion and otherwise accept the numbers presented in the PE (Post Election) column of the spreadsheet. No votes will be taken; this is the discussion portion of the process.

We completed going through the entire budget and held several items in each section for further discussion as continued below:

COA presentation on potential cost saving measures. Lennen suggested they could move to a digital flier with an opt-in to get paper for those without a computer. They are proposing removing \$4,500 from level services for a total ask of \$5,250.

Discussion on the library line items, there is a discrepancy in how state aid is accounted for in the budget. We currently budget such that the town pays for the entire library budget and the ~\$7,000 in state aid goes straight to free cash now. If we end up decreasing the library budget by this difference, the state may see this as decreasing the budget despite the actual total funding staying the same and we would like to avoid falling below the MAR. Schwelm has spoken with the state library association and they are very inflexible on this, but because we have taken out maintenance lines which will be paid for by the revolving fund from solar credits, this has effectively happened via other means. This leaves us at a few dollars above MAR which Meaghan feels is sufficient to provide level services.

The town Accountant and Treasurer have said we need to pay for an independent audit next year because we will be auditing the end of Joe Boudreau's tenure and a new accountant taking over, which is extra work and even more important than usual. Unfortunately, this will cost extra amounting to ~\$19,500.

Similar situation for the OPEB audit which will cost roughly \$7,500.

The OPEB trust line has periodically been zeroed out, but we should put a small amount in there ostensibly since this will be a boon for the rating we receive from the auditors.

Discussion of the FHD vs the town Board of Health line. Stanton was under the assumption that the FHD performed those duties, but there still must be a town component of this, legally speaking, so we need all three lines. That said, none of the members of the Board of Health have taken their stipend in recent years.

Discussion on the EMS Coordinator and its efficacy. The conclusion being that we should discuss this with the Fire Chief to understand the value and how best to fulfill the responsibilities. We are hoping the Chief can make it to a newly scheduled Monday meeting for this discussion.

Emergency Medical Services is the expenses for keeping equipment and training up to date. It has never been spent above \$6,000 so to match actuals, is it being lowered to \$6,000.

Police study results, the committee reached out to several surrounding towns about the potential of regionalization and got no response from all but one town which declined to discuss the effort further. Chesterfield and Williamsburg, being similar towns, would be the most likely to participate but since they are both in decent financial shape, they have little incentive to find savings in this way and as such declined the conversation.

Police Salary, there is still funding in the line item for an officer that has not yet been hired. Need to hear from the Chief about this some more, but the committee has decided to go with the Austerity budget number which excludes those funds, at least temporarily until we can discuss it with Chief White.

250th celebration, we have encumbered \$15k so far in this account, but it would not be fiscally responsible to save more this year considering the circumstances, we will have to revisit this next year and see if catch-up is possible. There was confidence that the state would match our projected savings total thus doubling money available. No good estimates exist for how much this will cost.

Assessors' expenses, they are moving the map data from a failing server hosted in the Annex building to the cloud. This will be an ongoing subscription cost but is a savings over time because we won't have to replace the hardware of the server for roughly ~\$10,000 and further pay our IT services to maintain it.

There was discussion of the Town Clerk and Town Coordinator positions – both hours worked and benefits received. No conclusions to those discussions. No immediate budgetary changes.

After tonight, without discussions on public works lines, we cut approximately \$9,000. The remaining deficit is ~\$329,000 as of tonight.

Milikowsky suggested WES may be willing to dip into a Revolving Fund and pay an additional \$45,000, thus lowering the remaining deficit to \$285,000. That was a proposal discussed at a School Committee meeting but apparently not voted on. We have invited the School Committee and admin to our 4/29 meeting. Hopefully, they can shed more light on this proposal.

Next meeting will be 4/27/26 @7pm and another following on 4/29/26 @7pm. We hope to have Police Chief, Highway Superintendent, and Fire Chief in attendance at the 4/27 meeting.

Motion to Adjourn at 9:45pm by Albitz, seconded by Durrin,

VOTE TO APPROVE: 7-0-0